This new hardship did me no harm at all and may even have forced me to grow up a little. Every morning, Riaan and I would make our special Bovril sandwiches, perfecting the art of spreading the Bovril and the butter on the hot toast so quickly that they would melt together; any other way affected the taste and was unacceptable. And the entire Van der Walt family could not have made me feel more at home. I was even able to sleep in my father's old bed, which had been moved from my grandparents' old house; his initials were engraved in the headboard.

My routine changed, but my burning ambition to play for the Wit Bulle remained the same and, just a week after being thrown out of the boarding house, I was named among the 1st XV substitutes for what would be a tough match against Die Brandwag from Humansdorp, ranked as the No. 4 school team in the country.

I was excited, nervous and relieved to see Danie Opperman would be playing at centre. This was the same Danie Opperman who had grown up with me in Warmbaths, the same Danie Opperman who had been my teammate at primary school, who had suggested to the coach that he move to centre so that I could play at flyhalf, who had applauded when I kicked the drop goal. Now, five years later, the same Danie Opperman was one of my teammates in the Affies 1st team, and he was still backing me.

With little more than 10 minutes to play, we were leading 21–9 and I was finally told to warm up and get ready to come on as a substitute flyhalf. I could not have been more thrilled and excited. With the entire school watching, I sprinted out to join the game and Danie Opperman gave me the thumbs-up.

My first pass was a skip pass, past Danie, into the hands of Deon Venter, our captain and outside centre, and my first place kick was a touchline conversion that sailed between the posts to secure the 28–9 win. What a day! The whole school was singing in full voice at the final whistle, and I could not have been happier.

A few more appearances as a substitute were followed by a couple